

Geography of the Indian Subcontinent

(Pakistan and Bangladesh)

Introduction : India, Pakistan, Bangladesh, Nepal, Bhutan, Myanmar and Sri Lanka, collectively constitute the Indian subcontinent.

These six countries are India's closest and nearest neighbours and share a common heritage of history and geography.

Pakistan

Location : Pakistan is our western neighbour.

It is bordered by Iran in the west, India in the east the Arabian Sea in the south and Afganistan in the North.

Latitude : Pakistan lies between 24°N and 37°N latitudes.

Longitude : It lies between longitudes 61°E and 75°E.

Area and composition : Pakistan has an area of about 3,12,685 sq. km. It comprises of West Punjab, Sind, Baluchistan, N.W.F.P. and a few tribal areas.

Physical Divisions of Pakistan : Pakistan may be divided into following four physical divisions :

The Northern and Western Highlands : The Hindukush mountains which extend from the Pamir Knot form a mountain wall in the north of Pakistan. Tirich Mir (7690 m) is the highest peak of the Hindukush.

1. The famous Khyber pass lies in this region.
2. Other important mountain ranges are Sulaiman range and Kirthar range.
3. These ranges spread in north-south direction.

The Baluchistan Plateau : Situated in the south-west of Pakistan.

4. It is a dry and rocky plateau with little vegetation.

The Indus Plain : Without the Indus, Pakistan would have been a complete desert. It is a 2700 km long fertile plain in the eastern Pakistan made by rich alluvial soil brought down by Indus and its five tributaries.

The Thar Desert : It is located in south-eastern part of Pakistan and continues into India.

Climate of Pakistan : The climate of Pakistan is one of the extremes.

5. It is very hot in summer and very cold in winter.
6. It gets little rainfall in summer.
7. The average rainfall in Pakistan is less than 25 cm in a year.
8. There is some rainfall in winter brought by the Western disturbances coming from the Mediterranean Sea.

Natural Vegetation

1. In plateaus, plains and desert mostly bushes, shrubs and coarse grasses are found.
2. In mountainous area in the north and west temperate deciduous trees, coniferous trees and alpine vegetation is found.

Language-Urdu, Currency-Rupee, Religion-Islam.

Economic Development

1. Agriculture : Rainfall in this agricultural country is very low and unreliable.
 2. Rivers and a developed network of canals make irrigation possible. Pakistan is known as the 'Land of Canals'. Mangla Dam and Tarbila Dam in Pakistan are very famous.
 3. Wheat, millets, cotton, rice, sugarcane and oil seeds are cultivated.
- Animal Rearing : People of Pakistan rear milch cattle.

4. Drought animals are also reared. Sheep and goats are reared in dry Baluchistan Plateau and the mountainous areas.

Mining : Mineral position of Pakistan is not satisfactory.

5. It has some deposits of petroleum, coal, iron and copper.
6. The gas fields of Sui is important.
7. Salt deposits near Khewra are well known.

Industrial Development : Industrial Pakistan is now well developed. Cotton textile, woolen textile, chemicals, cement, sugar, paper, etc. are important industries of Pakistan.

Carpets, embroidered goods, pottery and handicrafts are also manufactured here.
Population : Pakistan has a population of 153,960,000 (2005) excluding 4 million residents of Pakistan ruled Jammu and Kashmir and 01 million Afghan refugees.

8. The density of population is 170 persons per sq. km.
9. 90% people are Muslims, who follow Islam. Urdu is the state language.
Bangladesh

Bangladesh is our eastern neighbouring country.

Location : It is bordered on the north, west and east by India and on the south by the Bay of Bengal.

Latitude : Bangladesh lies between latitudes 21°N and 26°30'N. The Tropic of Cancer passes through the middle of it.

Longitude : It lies between longitudes 88°E and 92°30'E.

Physical Division of Bangladesh : Nearly whole of Bangladesh lies in the largest delta of the world.

1. It is a vast flat alluvial plain. It is a land of big rivers, lakes, swamps and marshes.
2. A large part of Bangladesh is flooded every year during rainy season.
3. It has an area of 1,47,570 sq. km.
4. The Jamuna (Brahmaputra), Padma (Ganga) and Meghna are the important rivers.
5. A small hilly area in the south-east forms the Chittagong Hill tract.

Climate

1. It has hot and humid climate.
2. Rainfall varies from 250 to 40 cm. It has distinct dry and rainy season.
3. In early summer, Bangladesh experiences cyclone storms.

Natural Vegetation

1. In the fringes of delta Mangrove forests are found.

2. Sundari and bamboo trees are found in these Sunderbans.

Agriculture

1. Because of fertile alluvial soil and abundant water supply, rice is the main crop of Bangladesh as it covers 85% of the cultivated area.
2. Jute the main cash crop.
3. Tea plantations are found in some areas in the north.
4. Sugarcane, cotton and tobacco are also grown.

Animal Rearing

1. Most of the animals reared in Bangladesh work as beasts of burden.
2. Bangladesh has become a leading supplier of animal hides and skins.

Fishing

1. Large number of rivers and nearness to the sea make fishing an important activity in Bangladesh.

Language—Bangla, Currency—Taka, Religion—Islam

Minerals

1. Bangladesh is not rich in mineral resources.
2. Coal, natural gas and oil are mined in a small quantity.

Industries

1. The important industries of Bangladesh include jute and cotton textiles, cement, fertilizers, sugar, paper, glass etc.

Population, Language and Religion

1. The population of Bangladesh is about 137,636,000 (2005).
2. The density of population here is 763 persons per sq. km.
3. Bengali is the official language of Bangladesh.
4. Most of the people follow Islam.

5. Dhaka, Chittagong, Khulna and Narayanganj are some of the important cities of Bangladesh.